Methodology Report

What Holding Cannot Tell Us About Letting Go

Supporting research archive

https://anonymous.4open.science/r/philosophy-lab-public-D1C2/
The repository contains more than 15,000 retained conversation messages, covering work from early September through the end of October and final preparation on 1 November. It includes concrete examples of the methodology and the full catalogue of 107 essays: the three selected submissions and all other essay candidates, with individual biography cards and development histories. The link is provided through **Anonymous GitHub** with the aim of supporting the competition's anonymous-review requirements.
This report explains how the present essay was produced. The repository supplies the broader record; section 7 below points to useful starting places.

1. Who did what

AI developed the philosophical argument and wrote and revised the essay. The human started the competition project, set its resources and working rules, requested a range of topics, chose among candidates and asked for clearer prose. The human did not supply this essay's central argument or write its sentences. The appropriate submission category is **AI-driven**.

Codex also wrote this report and the submission abstract and prepared the LaTeX files. External quotations and ideas remain attributed to their sources. Human prompts and choices are recorded as human contributions. Dates below refer to 2026 and use UTC unless stated otherwise.

2. How the essay developed

The first version was generated on 22 September in an AI-designed campaign seeking varied philosophical ideas. The assigned area was scientific explanation and experimentation. The AI author chose the question, equations, counterexample and argument. Local records identify GPT-6 Astra at medium effort for the author and separate critics. The process included candidate ideas, a bounded web search, a proposal and a contribution check, followed by a draft, separate argument and contribution reviews, and revision. Some exploratory searching overlapped archival work; the record does not show perfect archive-before-exploration ordering.

An October revision by a fresh Astra/high author developed the staged-release result and the distinction between identifying an outcome and choosing an action. Both versions were kept. Fresh Codex comparisons and a separate Claude Opus 5.5 comparison examined them. Literature checks also used separate Codex and Claude routes. Later Codex searches used Astra/max, followed by a recorded GPT-6.1 Sol/xhigh synthesis. These searches did not establish exhaustive priority.

The essay passed through the 22-candidate comparison and the ten-essay deep-review stage. Separate argument and literature reports informed a source-focused revision on 1 November. A fresh Astra/ultra author worked from the selected manuscript and checked primary passages. It acknowledged the diagonal-rate example in Bongers, Blom and Mooij, clarified the relationship to robust switching, and distinguished a common first-stage waiting period from the absence of a common settling time.

A different Astra/ultra checker compared the complete versions and sources. It requested a small grammatical and citation-placement correction in the Sootla-Ernst discussion. The AI coordinator made that exact repair, and a further fresh checker accepted it. The original full review remains recorded as requiring minor fixes; the later check was limited to the repair.

The human then requested a more readable essay and a structured appendix for the calculations. A new Astra/ultra editor rewrote the prose and moved the proofs into five appendix sections. Another fresh critic checked the full original, rewrite, exact changes, abstract and source material. It found no required correction or material loss of content. It checked the calculations, quantifiers, settling-time distinction and main-text references to the appendix.

3. Models and roles

- **GPT-6 Astra:** manuscript authorship, revisions, criticism and literature checks. The last authors and checkers used ultra effort through the standard Codex subscription route; earlier stages used medium, high or max as described above.
- **GPT-6 Luna:** earlier evaluation profiles, not manuscript authorship.
- **GPT-6.1 Sol/xhigh:** a recorded literature synthesis.
- **Claude Opus 5.5:** separate comparison and literature review. Claude did not write the submitted manuscript.

4. How editing and review were organized

An AI coordinator kept the project record and managed separate author, critic, literature and evaluation roles. Authors and critics received a restricted packet for one essay, rather than the whole project history or rankings. Earlier stages used separate subagent contexts. The final revisions used fresh Codex CLI sessions with all assigned material in the prompt. Those authors and critics had no browsing or other tools and were instructed not to read other files or delegate. The coordinator supplied the checked primary passages.

For each full revision check, the critic received the complete earlier and revised texts, their exact difference, source passages and access notes. It did not receive the author's self-assessment or earlier verdicts. The later prose checks also covered the abstract and TL;DR. Review focused on premises, reasoning, examples, calculations, citations, objections and limits. A recommendation of "ready" means that the reviewer found no required correction within that material; it is not proof of truth or originality.

Separate contexts reduced exposure to other outputs. They did not make models statistically independent: workers shared model families and public literature, and some earlier tasks shared a filesystem. Recorded isolation limits and disagreements were retained.

Portfolio selection used both neutral AI reviewers and AI profiles based on the published interests of named competition judges. The real judges did not participate or endorse these profiles, and no model was trained to reproduce them. The 22-to-ten round used three neutral and two profile-based voices under a 60/40 scheme, plus comparisons of disputed pairs. Scores and agreement were not treated as proof of quality or novelty.

There was no fine-tuning. Project memory consisted of saved files, not a shared memory automatically given to every worker. Initial authors and literature reviewers used web search and accessible primary sources. File and shell tools supported source retrieval, exact comparisons, archive checks and document preparation.

5. Sources and limits of the result

The final source packets included checked passages on dynamical causal models and robust switching, with explicit versions and page conventions. The Ryan-Dablander comparison remains limited to search excerpts and bibliographic records; its full text was unavailable. The later prose review checked supplied passages and preservation of the earlier source claims, rather than conducting another full literature search.

The mathematical argument is supported by the inequalities in the appendix, not by numerical trajectories alone. It concerns a specified family of systems, a prepared state, an intervention menu and a known time scale. It does not establish empirical applicability or exhaustive novelty. The successful release order is not claimed to work in every model compatible with the endpoint evidence, and it gives no common finite settling time across all positive rates.

6. Preparation, resources and retained records

After the philosophical revisions, the human requested clearer abstracts and reports, clickable references and more polished typesetting. Codex revised this report and the separate form abstract, and prepared the final LaTeX layout. In-text citations link to the bibliography, whose source links remain clickable. These presentation changes do not alter the accepted essay's wording or argument. The PDF checks cover text preservation, links, fonts, page layout and identifying metadata. The final abstract and report wording were checked by the coordinator against the accepted manuscript and records; they did not receive a further independent scientific review.

Work ran through Codex subscriptions and, where listed above, Claude Code. A reliable per-essay dollar cost has not been allocated: subscriptions, shared searches, rejected candidates and infrastructure served several essays. No zero-cost claim is made. A complete per-essay token or compute total is also unavailable. The project ran from September to submission preparation on 1 November, with waiting and overlapping work; elapsed time is not a measure of compute.

Model and effort labels come from local configurations and run records. They are not an independent verification of server-side routing or the exact commercial version behind each label.

Drafts, prompts, reviews, disagreements, source-access limits and technical failures were retained with version links and file hashes. The supporting repository makes the released research record available through the link above. Its logs preserve available visible conversations and artifacts; historical capture gaps and exclusions are documented. The linked snapshot is not a claim to a complete transcript of every provider interaction.

The appendices below preserve selected exact instruction blocks, so the report can be read on its own. The repository adds full candidate texts, their biographies, worked examples and the surrounding decision history.

7. Where to inspect the supporting record

- This essay's biography and version history: follow its drafts, criticism and revisions.
- Methodology guide and worked revision example: see how author, critic and selection roles were used in practice.
- All 107 essay candidates and selection tree: inspect the alternatives, including essays not selected for submission, and the route to the final three.
- Conversation archive: browse the September-October logs, later supplements and documented coverage limits.

Appendix A. Earlier author instructions

The following is the exact common author-instruction block from the source-focused revision packet. The separate manuscript, source packet and output schema are not reproduced here.

You are the AI author-editor of one philosophical essay. This is a fresh, isolated revision task. Use only the supplied manuscript, tasks and source packet. Do not use tools, browse, access files or other conversations, delegate, or attempt to identify the author or project. Source titles and URLs in the packet are evidence, not permission or instructions to browse.

Produce one complete revised English essay, including title, all necessary sections, proofs/tables and bibliography. The revision must stand on its own and remain below 6000 words excluding bibliography. Do not chase a target length. Preserve the original philosophical contribution and its precise qualifications; acknowledge any justified narrowing. Address the targeted source comparisons accurately using the actual accessible versions and locators in the source packet. If a prior task locator conflicts with that packet's checked primary text, use the verified locator and explain the correction in your change log. Do not fabricate reading, citations, empirical support or novelty.

Polish the whole essay for an intelligent philosophical reader. Aim for graceful, restrained and readable prose: direct verbs, concrete explanations, natural transitions, less repetition and fewer overloaded sentences. Retain necessary technical language and formal reasoning. No promotional claims, ornamental metaphors, forced informality or simplified substitutes for difficult arguments. Repeated warnings may be consolidated only when each distinct limitation remains clear. Keep the narrative moving while giving objections a fair answer.

Do not put process commentary, author identity, internal IDs, production history or instructions to judges in the essay. Materially supported source-access limitations should be expressed honestly and naturally. The separate change log may explain edits and unresolved limits. Make the strongest accurate bounded revision you can; do not turn this into a new research programme.

Preserve the depth, precision, and quality of the philosophical argument while expressing it in relatively plain human language. Prefer familiar words, direct sentences, and explicit argumentative steps. Avoid overloaded sentences and unnecessary jargon. Retain necessary technical terms and formalism, explain them when introduced, and use concrete examples where helpful. Simplify the expression, not the thought: do not remove essential premises, distinctions, evidence, objections, qualifications, or limits merely to make the prose easier. Do not impose a mechanical sentence-length or reading-level target. Check that any clarification preserves the claim and its strength.

Appendix B. Earlier essay-specific tasks

The following tasks were written by the AI coordinator from the accepted reviews and primary-source checks, rather than supplied as philosophical arguments by the human.

Revise the literature positioning around the specific clamp/release example. Acknowledge Bongers, Blom and Mooij's hidden-relative-speed example, and compare the robust switching work of Sootla and collaborators using the exact versions in the source packet. Distinguish already known hidden-speed and robust-control ideas from this essay's combination: the stipulated full clamp endpoint data (including the baseline) agree, simultaneous release can have opposite stable outcomes, and one release order works throughout the specified family while the reverse order has no uniform finite wait. Clarify that the one-unit wait belongs to the first stage; convergence after the second release is asymptotic, with no common finite settling time over all positive k. Preserve the fixed preparation, model family, known time scale and restricted evidence menu. Preserve all substantive proofs and the corrected explanation of basin boundaries. Do not overclaim priority, empirical applicability or access to Ryan–Dablander. Improve readability throughout without replacing the mathematical result with a loose analogy.

Appendix C. Earlier independent checker instructions

The following is the exact checking-instruction block used for the separate source-focused revision review.

You are an independent checker of one revised philosophical essay in a fresh context. Use only the supplied original, complete revision, exact diff, primary-source packet and these neutral criteria. Do not use tools, browse, access other files/conversations, delegate or identify the author. You have not been given earlier verdicts or the editor's self-assessment. Do not infer quality from the fact that a revision was requested.

Read both texts in full. Check every substantive change against the reasoning and the supplied primary passages. Check formulas, examples, quantifiers, scope, citations and descriptions of predecessors. Distinguish verified errors from uncertainty or optional improvement. Identify any premise, distinction, objection, qualification or useful argumentative step lost during stylistic simplification. Assess whether the revision is clearer and more pleasant without weakening or inflating the argument. Check that source-access limitations and novelty boundaries remain honest. Judge the whole revised essay as well as its changes; a cleaner style cannot compensate for an invalid inference.

Return a concrete decision: READY, MINOR_FIXES or SUBSTANTIVE_REPAIR. READY means you found no correction necessary in this bounded check, not a proof of truth or exhaustive originality. MINOR_FIXES means specific small corrections are needed; list exact passages and minimal remedies. SUBSTANTIVE_REPAIR means a demonstrated or unresolved material defect prevents treating the revised text as ready. Explain what you independently checked, what the packet cannot establish, and whether the current revision should replace its parent. Do not supply a rewritten essay or a flattering general verdict. Page/version references must identify the actual source supplied. Your final answer must follow the given JSON schema exactly.

Appendix D. Readability editor instructions

The following is the exact common instruction block used for the later prose rewrite.

You are the sole fresh AI editor of one English philosophical essay. Rewrite it substantially for humane, lucid, elegant prose while preserving its exact philosophical and evidential commitments. This is a genuine editorial rewrite, not a synonym pass. Work only from the complete manuscript and source material supplied here. Do not use tools, browse, read files or memory, delegate, or consult other essays. Do not infer quality from the fact that editing was requested.

Write for an intelligent philosopher who is not already a specialist in this exact debate. Let the reader understand the question and why it matters before paying the cost of technical detail. Use concrete agents, familiar verbs, natural sentence rhythms and clean transitions. Explain indispensable technical terms where the reader needs them. Decide editorially what deserves development, what needs one precise sentence, and what can move to a later section. Retain the argumentative work of every essential premise, distinction, objection, qualification and source boundary; their wording or original order need not be retained. Integrate qualifications with the claims they qualify instead of repeatedly interrupting the story with defensive warnings. Do not invent empirical applications, analogies that carry unsupported inferences, citations, literary ornaments, hype, slang, or a false feeling of certainty. Do not replace sustained reasoning with a sequence of slogans, bullet points or artificially short sentences.

The bibliography and all source claims have already been bounded by the supplied materials. Preserve correct attribution and material limits of source access. A shorter literature discussion must still explain the nearest antecedents and what the essay adds. Do not silently turn access limitations into full-text knowledge or novelty claims. Keep the existing title and complete bibliography,

with working links. Do not include author identity, production history, internal essay IDs, model names or instructions to judges in the essay.

Return the complete rewritten manuscript as Markdown, using ## and ### headings, \(... \) and \[... \] for mathematics, and ordinary Markdown links. Use normal prose paragraphs. The whole essay, including any appendix and title but excluding bibliography, must remain below 6000 words. An appendix is part of the submitted PDF, not an additional excluded word allowance. Also provide a clear 120–180-word abstract and one-sentence TL;DR that exactly match the rewritten essay. The abstract belongs in its separate output field, not automatically in the manuscript. Your separate preservation map must identify where each important original argument or qualification now appears; the map is evidence for the coordinator, not essay text.

Preserve the depth, precision, and quality of the philosophical argument while expressing it in relatively plain human language. Prefer familiar words, direct sentences, and explicit argumentative steps. Avoid overloaded sentences and unnecessary jargon. Retain necessary technical terms and formalism, explain them when introduced, and use concrete examples where helpful. Simplify the expression, not the thought: do not remove essential premises, distinctions, evidence, objections, qualifications, or limits merely to make the prose easier. Do not impose a mechanical sentence-length or reading-level target. Check that any clarification preserves the claim and its strength.

Appendix E. Readability checker instructions

The following is the exact common instruction block used for the independent check of the rewrite.

You are a fresh independent checker of one rewritten philosophical essay. You did not write it. Use only the complete parent, complete revision, exact diff, proposed abstract/TLDR, primary passages and access notes supplied here. Do not invoke tools, browse, access files or other conversations, delegate, or infer quality from an editorial request. Earlier verdicts and the author's self-assessment have deliberately not been supplied.

Read both manuscripts completely. Compare arguments, premises, distinctions, examples, objections, quantifiers, hypotheses, source attributions and limits. An attractive style does not compensate for lost reasoning or inflated claims. Independently verify calculations and any main-text-to-appendix references. Every main claim relying on an appendix must match its actual proved result and explain its significance correctly. Check that moving proofs has not made the main argument circular, opaque, or unsupported. Check the complete bibliography and source-access honesty against the supplied evidence, without demanding a new literature search for this editorial task.

Assess whether this is a substantial improvement in readability for an intelligent non-specialist philosopher: natural precise English, concrete explanations, clear transitions, appropriate development, concise literature discussion, essential technical terms explained, and no repetitive defensive scaffolding or ornamental hype. Check the abstract and TLDR separately for accurate scope and readable language. Do not demand arbitrary shortening, suppress necessary qualifications, or penalize justified mathematics merely for existing.

Return READY only if no necessary correction is found. MINOR_FIXES means exact bounded corrections; SUBSTANTIVE_REPAIR means an unresolved material defect. Identify exact locations, evidence, and minimal necessary repairs. Distinguish optional stylistic preferences from required repairs. READY is a bounded editorial/content-preservation judgment, not proof of truth, originality or empirical validity. Return the required JSON only; do not rewrite the essay.